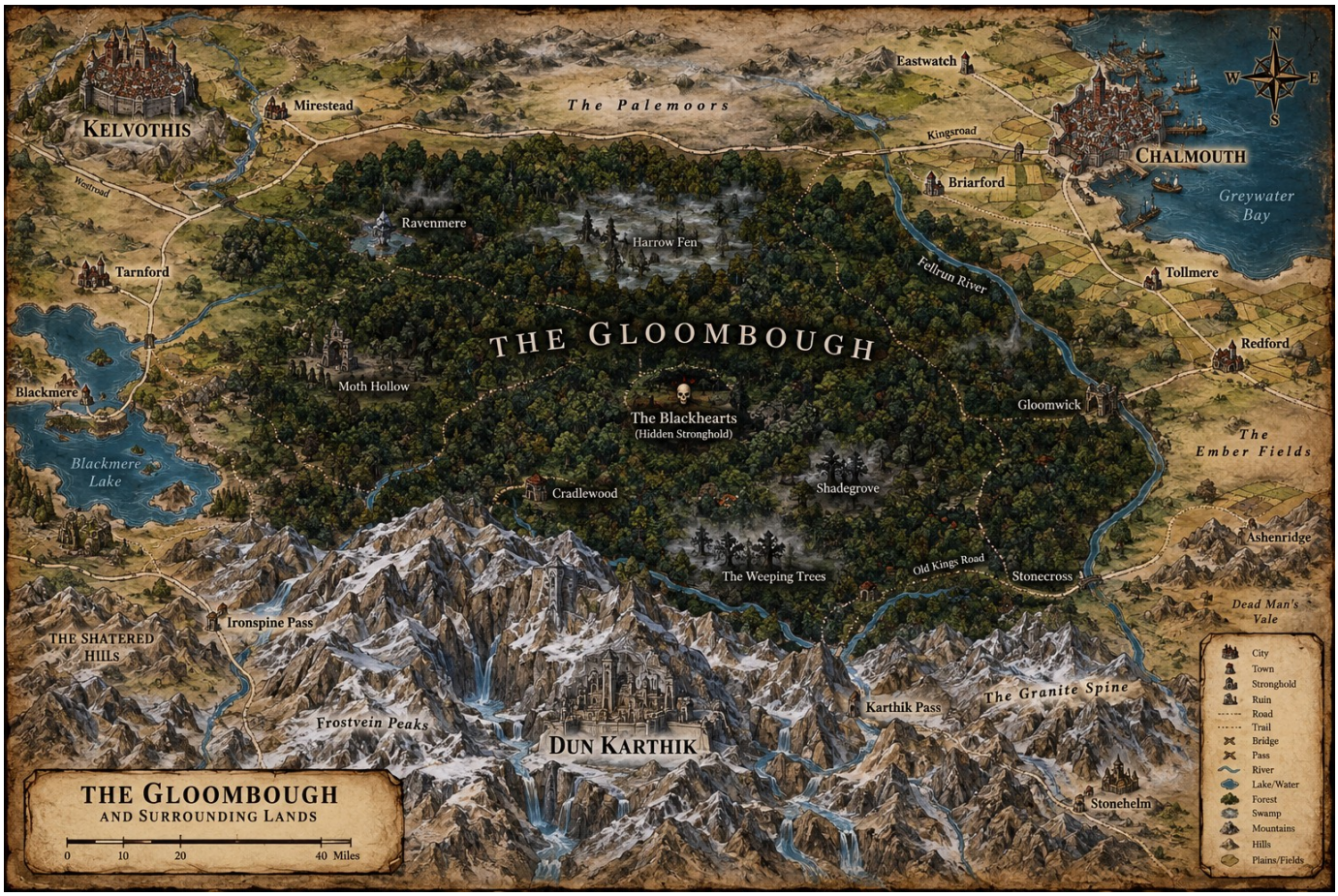
THE BLACKHEARTS

A GAZETTEER OF THE GLOOMBOUGH

A Traveler's Guide to the Borderlands



Kelvothis to the west. Chalmouth to the east. Dun Karthik in the southern mountains. Between them stretches the Gloombough: a forest of old roads, old grudges, and older secrets.

A public account of settlements, trade, roads, terrain, and figures known across the region. Some local reports are rumor, not verified fact.

I. The Three Great Powers

Kelvothis

Western fortified city of rocky uplands and fertile valleys. Old nobility and merchant wealth compete for power.

Population: 38,000; Human 78%; halfling, dwarf and half-elf minorities.

Resources and industries: Grain, wool, cattle, leather, finance, road tolls.

Notable figures: Prince Edric Valmont; Lady Seraphine Valmont; Lord Garrick Voss; Marshal Theodric Hale.

Landmarks: Citadel of Nine Towers; Goldweigh Exchange; Old Gallows; wine vaults.

Chalmouth

Major eastern port on Greywater Bay, governed by a Merchant Council of Seven. Cosmopolitan trade conceals severe commercial rivalries.

Population: 46,000; Human 72%; dwarf 10%; halfling 8%; elf/half-elf 6%; others 4%.

Resources and industries: Shipping, shipbuilding, fishing, salt, rope, warehouses, insurance.

Notable figures: High Factor Lucien Marr; Admiral Ysabet Crowe; Magistrate Corvin Pell; Lady Helena Drey.

Landmarks: Seven Quays; Blackwater Prison; Salt Exchange; Admiralty Tower; Lantern Market.

Dun Karthik

Vast fortified dwarven citadel carved into the northern Frostvein Peaks. Guild rivalries are fierce despite a culture of craftsmanship.

Population: 21,000; Dwarf 93%; human and gnome merchant enclaves.

Resources and industries: Iron, copper, silver, coal, granite, gemstones; smithing, mining, masonry.

Notable figures: High Thane Borund Karthik; Forge-Matron Hilda Bronzefist; Captain Dorrim Ironward; Fenrik Coalvein.

Landmarks: Hall of Seven Hammers; Deep Forges; King’s Anvil; Iron Market; Black Delves.

II. Towns and Border Settlements

Mirestead • 1,150 residents

Wind-battered northern pastures and peat bogs; insular farming community.

People and economy: Mostly human; halfling farming families; Sheep, peat, wool, mutton, rough cloth.

Authority: Reeve Oswin Tallow.

Landmarks: Crooked Ewe Inn; shearing grounds; abandoned watchtower.

Eastwatch • 620 residents

Fortified northern outpost controlling a Chalmouth approach.

People and economy: Soldiers, stablehands, merchants and families; mostly human; Military tolls, horses, garrison supply.

Authority: Captain Alric Dane.

Landmarks: Eastwatch Tower; King’s Road Stables; toll barracks.

Briarford • 1,850 residents

Prosperous eastern farming town on the main road west of Chalmouth.

People and economy: Mostly human; farming and milling households; Wheat, barley, fruit, watermills, regional trade.

Authority: Lady Marwen Rusk.

Landmarks: Three Mills; Briarford Market; Rusk Manor.

Tarnford • 1,300 residents

Rugged western livestock market near the Blackmere basin.

People and economy: Human, halfling and some half-orc drovers; Cattle, hides, tanning, fishing.

Authority: Bailiff Joren Pike.

Landmarks: Ox and Cleaver Inn; stockyards; Pike’s Tannery.

Blackmere • 900 residents

Flood-prone lakeside peninsula settlement with stone-founded houses.

People and economy: Mostly human fishing families; Fish, reeds, small-boat trade.

Authority: Elder Maela Venn.

Landmarks: Drowned Bell Tavern; Fishermen’s Shrine; old cemetery.

Tollmere • 1,100 residents

Eastern coaching town among cultivated fields.

People and economy: Mostly human; farmers, merchants and travelers; Agriculture, inns, road services.

Authority: Sir Alden Breck.

Landmarks: Silver Wheel Coaching House; Breck Hall; grain market.

Redford • 1,700 residents

Prosperous southeast market settlement near the Ember Fields.

People and economy: Mostly human farming households; Grain, livestock, mills, river commerce.

Authority: Baron Cedric Wyle.

Landmarks: Redford Granary; Wyle Manor; Old Stone Chapel.

Gloomwick • 480 residents

Isolated village on the Gloombough’s eastern margin above the Fellrun.

People and economy: Human woodcutters and trappers; some half-orcs; Timber, charcoal, trapping, river landing.

Authority: Headman Edrin Moss.

Landmarks: Hanging Lantern Inn; Charcoal Yard; ruined watchpost.

Cradlewood • 210 residents

Tiny woodland community near southern foothills and forgotten paths.

People and economy: Forest families, mostly human with some elves and half-elves; Hunting, herbs, timber, trapping.

Authority: Elder Brynna Holt.

Landmarks: Old Cradle Inn; Tallow House; abandoned shrine.

Stonecross • 750 residents

Fortified crossing of the Fellrun, strategically vital to mountain trade.

People and economy: Mostly human; dwarven traders pass through; Bridge tolls, quarrying, caravan services.

Authority: Castellan Roderic Flint.

Landmarks: Stonecross Bridge; Flint's Watchtower; Broken Wheel Inn.

Ashenridge • 530 residents

Smoky eastern highland village on the approach to Dead Man's Vale.

People and economy: Mostly human miners and charcoal burners; Charcoal, ironstone, low-grade coal.

Authority: Reeve Marta Crenn.

Landmarks: Black Kilns; Crenn's Storehouse; abandoned Ashen Mine.

Stonehelm • 1,400 residents

Partly surface-built dwarven satellite town east of Dun Karthik.

People and economy: Predominantly dwarven; human traders; Mining, masonry, stoneworking, ore trade.

Authority: Thane Durgan Stonehelm.

Landmarks: Stonehelm Quarry; Hammer Gate; Hall of Contracts.

III. The Gloombough Forest

The Outer Boughs hold hunters, charcoal burners and managed timber. The Middle Gloom is a dense, dangerous woodland of forgotten paths. The Deep Gloom is old-growth wilderness where the ordinary rules of travel and survival become unreliable. The forest's thick canopy, ravines, wetlands and fallen timber frustrate organized patrols.

IV. Wild Places, Waters, and Mountains

The Gloombough

Old-growth oak, ash, beech, elm and pine; Outer Boughs, Middle Gloom, Deep Gloom. Timber, game, herbs and hidden trails.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Unusual timber.

Ravenmere

Ruined noble lakeside manor in the northwestern woods, surrounded by black pools and marsh.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Old ruins and lost property have drawn occasional explorers.

Harrow Fen

Northern peat marsh, flooded islands, black pools, treacherous fog.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Rare medicinal plants.

Moth Hollow

Ruined western religious sanctuary with crypts and pale moth swarms.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Old ruins and lost property have drawn occasional explorers.

Shadegrove

Dense southeastern woodland over ancient ruins; almost no light reaches the ground.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Old ruins and lost property have drawn occasional explorers.

The Weeping Trees

Southern grove of pale trees exuding dark resin; headaches and disorientation reported.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Rare resin.

Frostvein Peaks

Snowy southwest granite range with glaciers, waterfalls and mineral seams.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Iron.

Granite Spine

Jagged southeast mountain chain with dry valleys and remote prospecting camps.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Granite.

Shattered Hills

Western limestone outcrops, sinkholes, old quarries and narrow valleys.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Flint.

Ironspine Pass

Western mountain wagon road with dwarven drainage and stone bridges.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Ore.

Karthik Pass

Maintained eastern route from Dun Karthik toward Stonehelm.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Ore.

Dead Man’s Vale

Dry eastern valley where an army was annihilated generations ago.

Travel note: Conditions vary seasonally; reports of predators, ruins and missing travelers should be treated seriously.

Known resources: Old ruins and lost property have drawn occasional explorers.

Blackmere Lake

Dark western lake fed by mountain streams; wooded bluffs, reedbeds and islands.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Pearls.

Fellrun River

Rocky upper reaches, deeper channels and floodplain along the eastern forest.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Timber.

Greywater Bay

Sheltered maritime inlet, reefs, fog, islands and the port of Chalmouth.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Wreck cargo.

The Palemoors

Wind-scoured northern heath, grazing land, peat bogs and burial mounds.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Wool.

The Ember Fields

Fertile red-soil farmland southeast of the forest; grain and orchards.

Travel note: Travel is possible with preparation, though weather, wildlife and isolation remain concerns.

Known resources: Grain.

V. Roads and Commerce

Kingsroad

Northern east–west trade highway between Kelvothis and Chalmouth

Common risks: Highwaymen, toll collectors, occasional patrols.

Old King’s Road

Partially neglected southern forest-edge route near Stonecross

Common risks: Ambushes, floods, broken bridges.

Valroad / Western Road

Western approach from Kelvothis toward Tarnford and lake country

Common risks: Cattle thieves, brigands.

Ironspine Route

Western lowlands to Dun Karthik

Common risks: Rockfalls, raiders.

Karthik Road

Dun Karthik through Stonehelm toward the east

Common risks: Ore theft, caravan attacks.

Gloombough Trails

Hunters' paths, logging tracks, secret routes

Common risks: Predators, hostile gangs, disorientation.

VI. Regional Relations

Kelvothis controls inland agriculture, landed wealth and finance. Chalmouth controls coastal shipping and imported goods. Dun Karthik supplies metalwork, stone and skilled engineering. Their mutual dependence sustains commerce, while competition over tariffs, routes and influence strains diplomacy. The forest frontier lies beyond the reliable reach of any one government.

VII. Advice for Travelers

Travel in company, hire guides for forest paths, verify tolls before departure, and do not assume that a settlement's laws extend beyond its walls. Skilled craftspeople, sound equipment and trustworthy information are among the region's most valuable assets.